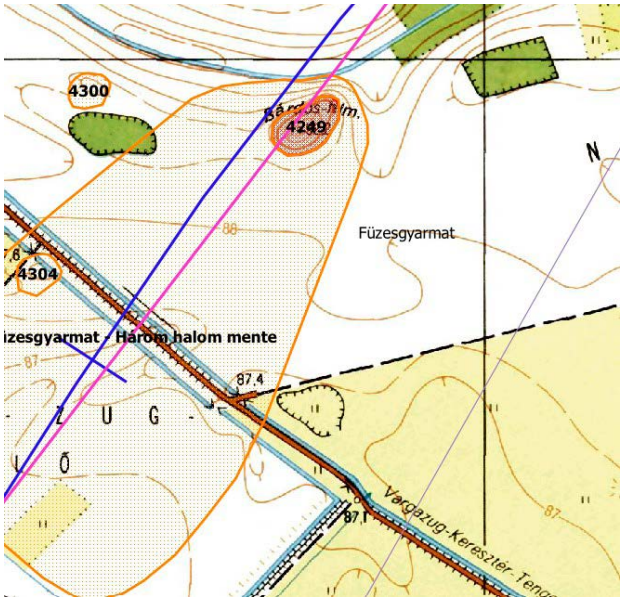

Figure 39: M47 motorway through the archaeological site of Bárdos-halom. The previous line – magenta, and the new one – blue (drawn by M. Koller)

Figure 40: The Bárdos-kurgan from South in 2009 (source: Bede 2014,166.)

Description of the site

The height of the tumulus is 2.7m, the longer diameter is 75m, the shorter 55m and it is under agricultural cultivation. In the Füzesgyarmat microregion this is one of the biggest mounds, its character remarkably well preserved despite the fact that it is ploughed (Fig.40).

In 2019, an archaeological site was identified around the mound that was inhabited through several archaeological periods – Neolithic, Copper Age-Early Bronze Age, Iron Age, Sarmatian, Avar, Árpádian Period and Late Middle Ages. The site also includes a smaller, nameless kurgan, and nearby, about 210 m west of the Bárdos-kurgan, there is another small mound (Fig. 41). The surrounding archaeological site, which appears to be intense on the surface, could not be avoided by the planned investment, because the area is rich in hydrocarbons and is being exploited in the deeper eastern area outside the site.

Assessing significance – methods and results

Tumuli like these should be assessed primarily for their role in the landscape and for the aspect of nature protection, because these are the best way to ensure their practical conservation. Therefore certain categories can be established for the ranking of tumuli based on their large number and different condition, further their historical and landscape value.

The first category are significant kurgans which are defining landscape features in terms of their size and appearance, and further preference for their categorisation is the vegetation on them – for example natural plant associations, ancient grassland, etc. – and also other historical values such as a medieval church or cemetery. These features should be avoided by development and preferably be declared a protected archaeological site. The tumuli of the second category are more disturbed so they cannot dominate the landscape, are no longer considered to be significant.

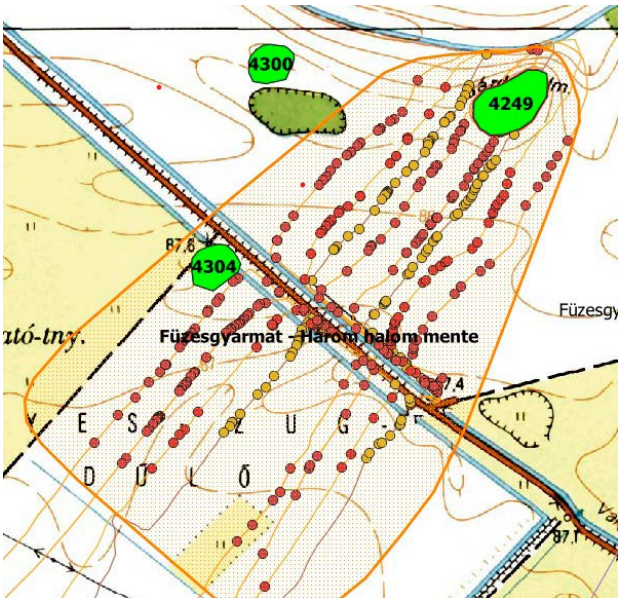

Figure 41: Bárdos-halom and the archaeological site in its vicinity. Result of the intensive field survey supported by GPS (drawn by M. Koller)

Destroyed mounds form a further category, which have either been completely ploughed or removed, so that the above surface part has been destroyed, but the central burial remains below ground. A variant of this is where both the burial and the mound is completely destroyed. The last two categories can be excavated with full-surface excavation, however the completely destroyed kurgans can be documented by archaeological observation.

Conclusions

Economic interests usually do not take archaeological heritage into account. But occasionally, heritage management can intervene to accomplish the following goals:

- The significant kurgans or other heritage values are not damaged, destroyed or covered by the investments.
- Different types of protection can be extended to same site, for example the cooperation with nature conservation institutions can successfully be used on archaeological sites, especially on kurgans (Fig.42).
- Arousing the interest of local communities usually works in the case of visually significant archaeological sites.

Possible equipment of the heritage management consists of:

- constant communication with designer offices
- collaboration with nature conservation institutions
- education (presentation) and interaction with local communities in frames of community archaeology.

Figure 42: Ancient steppe vegetation on Szálka-kurgan in Hortobágy National Park (source: https://hu.wikipedia.org/wiki/Kunhalom#/media/F%C3%A1jl:Szalkahalom.jpg)